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## Globalizing racial triangulation: including the people and nations of color on which White supremacy depends

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### ABSTRACT

Racial triangulation theory brilliantly conjoins, at once, two different types of racialized hierarchies, thereby allowing more than the metrics of standard anti-African American racism (“the color line”) to be theorized. This is one of the hallmarks of the pathbreaking model. At the same time, this essay chronicles how racial triangulation falls prey to the common social science tendency of US centrism, nation-state singularity, and catch-all models, omitting the influence of (neo)imperialism, (neo/post)colonialism, neoliberalism, and other foundational projects of global and American racism. For instance, U.S. empire – i.e., militarist, capitalist, cultural dominance – means that most Asian ethnic groups experienced racial injustice and a version of racial triangulation in their sending countries before migration; in turn, the pre-migrant context profoundly shapes how the US racializes/positions these groups (often vis-a-vis one another) and how the margins respond. In addition, racial triangulation privileges eastern-descent ethnics, overlooks anti-South Asian American racism in the post-1980s and post-9/11 era, underappreciates Asian/Asian American resistance, and neglects to theorize those positioned at the intersection of “inferior” and “foreigner” (of which former President Barack Obama is emblematic). In spite of the (constructive) criticism, in this era of Covid-19 racism, the Atlanta Massacre, widespread state murder of Black Americans, anti-Latinx/-Mexican nativist racism, and Muslim Bans, we need to expand racial triangulation theory, not dismiss it.

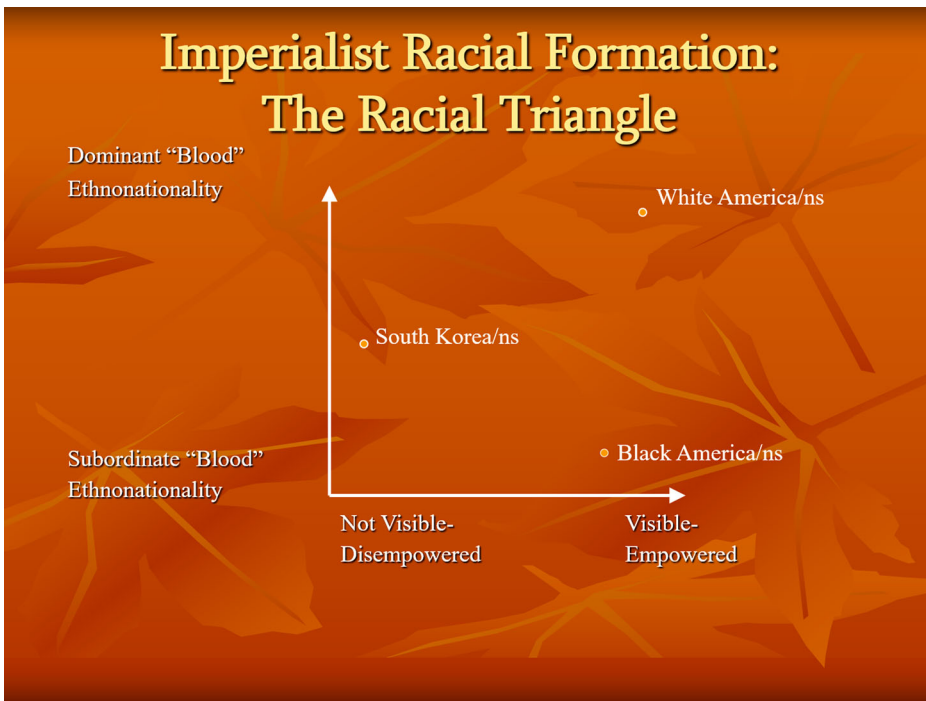
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Claire Jean Kim (1999)’s model of racial triangulation was and remains a groundbreaking theory of race and racism, one that did not commit the common error of reducing myriad racial groups in the United States to irrelevance if they were not White or Black American. The theory brilliantly conjoins, at once, two different types of racialized hierarchies, thereby allowing more than the metrics of standard anti-African American racism (“the color line”) to be theorized. Not only did it achieve this by giving primacy to the “citizenship line,” one marked by the poles of “Foreigner” and “Insider,” but also by racialization processes that triangulate groups into their respective social positions, such as “relative valorization” and “civic ostracism.”



**Figure 1.** Imperialist Racial Formation (The Racial Triangle) in South Korea.

At the same time, this essay will elaborate on a critique of how racial triangulation falls prey to the common social science tendency of US centrism, nation-state singularity, and catch-all models, omitting the influence of (neo)imperialism, (neo/post)colonialism, neoliberalism,<sup>1</sup> and other foundational projects of global and American racism. To be sure, Kim acknowledges that Asian Americans (which she conflates with mostly East Asian ethnics, a critique I address later) experience racism in part because they are conflated with Asian nations abroad. Yet, I argue that this dimension of racial triangulation needed much more development. That is, U.S. empire – i.e., militarist, capitalist, cultural dominance – means that most Asian ethnic groups experienced racial injustice *and* a version of racial triangulation in their sending countries before migration. This pre-migrant experience of race/racism fundamentally shapes the views and actions of Asian and other immigrants of color once they are part of domestic US racial orders. In this way, Kim, like others, does not consider the cross-border dimensions of racialization (e.g., White, Asian, Black, Latinx) nor does she theorize, as George Lipsitz (1998) would, the *multiple* interrelated racial hierarchies that exist in the United States and in geopolitical territories imprinted by USAmerican power.

### **A racial triangulation that crosses borders**

To flesh out this critique by way of example, my book *Imperial Citizens: Koreans and Race from Seoul to LA* (2008) drew on the innovative, generative tenets of racial triangulation while it also sought to remap it. Doing so allowed me to grasp the 1992 uprisings as

well as the immigrant and South Korean experience in a (neo)imperialist US context. That is, once we see 1992 and Korean America within a transnational racial context of power (not just an event tied to “LA”), it is impossible not to center a cross-border triangulated field, or an “imperialist racial formation” (see Omi and Winant 1994). In this (neo)imperialist context, Asians as well as their immigrant brethren are racialized and shaped by US relations with purported Asian “homelands,” irrespective of whether or not the immigrants are connected to these places. To study any group that is dominated by White Western (neo)imperialism/colonialism requires models that examine racialization processes in two unequally-positioned nation-states and/or that fuse the two major processes of racialization (arguably, a tall theoretical order). For most groups of color in the United States, especially those with sizable immigrant populations, we need such new theoretical paradigms. Racial triangulation is a scintillating start.

In my book I did not overlay the two but rather proposed distinct, albeit related, racial fields of triangulation (the sending and receiving societies). In examining the racism that the United States institutionalized in South Korea long before most Koreans arrived to the USA *en masse* – namely, the White over Black order and a (mostly White) American over Korean order – I drew on and reconceptualized racial triangulation by relating these to South Korea’s own internal social orders. For instance, South Koreans’ concerns pertain to their place in the US-led racialized global economic order *as well as* the US domestic order, not merely the latter. Conjoining racial triangulation theory and racial formation theory, I found that South Koreans positioned themselves between White and nonWhite countries/peoples along a vertical axis (per the global economic and color-class orders); at the same time, on a horizontal axis of political recognition – among the most important metrics for a highly nationalistic country – they positioned South Korea on the “weak” end of the pole (the world knows less about Koreans/Asians) while they located White and Black America on the “strong” end (the world refers to them most, Blacks have gained politically, e.g., politicians, military, pop culture). The fact that South Korea today still worries about its global stature and image even after becoming the 11th largest economy in the globe and a dominant soft power (from kimchi to *Parasite* to BTS) bespeaks its own admission that it has not fully “arrived.”

Beyond South Korea, racial triangulation’s more focused meditation on the effects of Orientalist, imperialist, and colonial conquests by the West – and their imported racial orders and discourse – could have demonstrated more explicitly how these forms of “Asia” are inseparable from Asian American bodies. In this vein, Kim’s evidence for civic ostracism could have included Western powers’ age-old construction of Asian nations as weak and diseased, the historical antecedent for today’s widespread “kung flu” racism against anyone who resembles Chinese Americans. From 1869 to 1887, for instance, White society excoriated San Francisco’s Chinese ethnics for “causing” four different outbreaks of smallpox (Shah 2001), a disease that in fact originated in Europe and was at the root of the germ-genocide of Native populations. Similarly, Chinese Americans (and people mistaken for them) were also blamed for the transmission of syphilis to “pure” White bodies in the mid-1870s. Racializing Asians and Asian immigrants as a foreign, threatening virus reached a fever pitch when, in 1899, White Americans torched Honolulu’s Chinatown for being nothing but a hotbed of contagion (rumored bubonic plague); other Chinatowns would face a similar fate.

To be sure, Kim could not have anticipated that some years after her publication, Chinese Americans would be attacked for infecting the United States with the deadly SARS (Fang 2020), and in 2009, China would be blamed for the H1N1 flu despite its first discovery in the Stars and Stripes. Yet, since the beginning, Chinese ethnics were used to justify America's "long history of immigrant exclusion on the basis of disease," as "codified in the 1882 [Chinese] Exclusion Act" and in the 1875 Page Law (Little 2020), which forbade entry to Chinese women sex workers for fear of their widespread and "exotic" sexual diseases. Combine Orientalism, White nationalism, and an American exceptionalism that likes to blame "foreign" nations for health crises, and it's no wonder that, historically, Asian ethnics were reduced to viruses, which President Trump has resurrected for his anti-China/-Chinese demagoguery.

Similarly, more attention to how Britain and the US racialized Indian and other South Asian immigrants in their origins would help us grasp the rise of hate crimes against the group that began in the 1980s, particularly in New Jersey by the White-Latinx militia "Dotbusters," and as they proliferated in engineering and high-tech and as convenience store owners, motel proprietors, and taxi drivers. The Dotbusters, for instance, committed a range of racist violence, from beating South Asian Americans into comas to the brutal 1987 murder of Navroze Mody by brick (yet no murder charges were filed). Integrating South Asian ethnics would have also addressed one of the shortcomings of racial triangulation: its definition of "Asian Americans" as largely those of eastern descent, save a reference to the Supreme Court's denial of citizenship to Bhagat Singh Thind (also omitted are Filipinx Americans). The 1980s spike in anti-foreigner hate crimes against South Asian Americans would have then served as precursor to the drastic spike in violence in the post 9/11 era, including the murder of Balbir Singh Sodhi for supposedly being "Al-Qaeda" and, later, of his brother. To be sure, racial triangulation was published prior to 2001, however, this does not justify the elision of South Asian ethnics in the "Asian American" category nor of their own deadly bouts with civic ostracism, historically and up to 1999. I believe that greater attention to White-led countries' exploits in sending Asian nations, and how these inform why Americans perceive South Asian ethnics to be Muslim terrorists (some also hurt by Trump's Muslim Ban), would have prevented the elision.

In a related vein, racial triangulation would also be strengthened by a more explicit and capacious inclusion of other groups of color. For example, although Kim chooses to use only Asian Americans to flesh out the horizontal axis of citizenship inequality, it should certainly be applicable to Latinxs and to Pacific Islander and Muslim/Middle Eastern Americans (and the ethnic variation therein). Civic ostracism can certainly be made specific to the case of Latinxs, a group that has been racialized as foreigners largely on the basis of *legal* status, but also by way of United States–Latin American relations (nation, globalization).

## Two orthogonal axes: at once productive and limiting

In this section, I chronicle how one of the greatest contributions of racial triangulation theory – its two orthogonal axes (which I have used extensively) – are also its most limiting. As one example, the horizontal axis of "Insider" – "Foreigner" – and the process of civic ostracism on which it pivots – cannot account for Asian Americans' (and some

Asian nations') *weak* political visibility, power, and resources. I contend that White America does not render Asian Americans "foreigners" solely by *civically ostracizing* them. The dominant group also "foreignizes" Asian groups by *not* being familiar with or concerned with them, relegating them to the status of invisibility or partial presence (Espiritu 2003, 47). Being an unrecognized, and thus insignificant and ignored, subject is especially devastating inasmuch as identities themselves do not exist outside of recognition (see Gutmann 1994). To be certain, being visibly foreign as well as invisible overlap and can be mutually constitutive. Given Asian Americans' greatest *visibility* in U.S. racial discourse as model minorities (though that has currently shifted), they have been rendered *invisible* in the discourse on who is harmed by racism in the United States. In the words of Edward Said, populations who are excluded are valuable precisely because they are not fully present. In short, social citizenship concerns are tied to invisibility as much as to violence against a visible outsider. In their patterned responses to this injustice, I have found that Korean immigrants have not just sought to keep a racial order intact that locates them in the middle as "model minorities," but have long sought to *disrupt* their foreigner position and thereby *alter* the racial order. They do so in part by working to overturn their racialized invisibility and foreignness. As Kim's own data show, Korean American merchants sought to familiarize Blacks and the mainstream writ large to the plight of otherwise unknown Korean Americans and South Korea (Kim 2000). Inspired by racial formation theory, this begs the question of how resistance movements forge and shift race/racist dynamics in the United States under a regime of racial triangulation (see Omi and Winant 1994).

In a related vein, Kim's two axes of Superior-Inferior (what I call the "color line") and Insider-Foreigner (what I deem the "citizenship line") should actually cross and/or be interrelated in some kind of fashion. For one, the citizenship line is just as much a hierarchy as the color line, hence, a horizontal line is limiting. That is to say, this axis needs to capture what Gary Okihiro (1994, 142) argues is the circularity between these two racial locations; he writes, the model minority and the yellow peril are not poles but "form a circular relationship that moves in either direction." In other words, although Asian Americans' success can incite anti-yellow peril discrimination, the (feminized) model minority image can assuage fears of a (masculinized) yellow peril, enabling the representations to exist side by side (Okihiro 1994; see Espiritu 1997). By arguing thus, Okihiro also interrelates race and gender in a way we do not see with racial triangulation.

And what of the Asian and Black Americans who would occupy an interrelated "Inferior-Foreigner" position? Consider Barack Obama (see Kim 2010). Obama was an "inferior" Black man who was equated with monkeys and was so reviled that he needed security detail earlier and to a much greater extent than any POTUS before him (vertical "color line"). Simultaneously, he suffered a racialization usually reserved for Asian Americans or Latinxs, that of a non-American (horizontal "citizenship line"), specifically, anti-Muslim and anti-Asian racializations when he was conflated with the most populous Muslim nation in the world, Indonesia (which is in Asia), and when his links to Hawai'i, an Asian-majority state, was used to question his "American-ness" and his birth certificate (recall that Trump was one of the most prominent birthers) (Kim 2010). Racist Americans spread the rumor that during Obama's 2.5 years in Indonesia, he had attended a "radical" madrassa, a breeding ground for terrorists. As such, the "yellow peril" and the "brown peril" are synonymous. Furthermore, this happened in the

context of fear-mongering over the “browning of America,” since Obama’s father was from Kenya, and since being against immigrants has long meant being against Latinx ethnics (often, “Mexicans”) (Kim 2010). As the racist adage goes, “they raid” Whites’ once pristine shores, white picket fence communities, and places of work, all precursors to Trumpian white racist nationalism.

Hence, Barack Hussein Obama, and any Black person in the United States with a name and story divergent from the slave-descendant African American narrative, are likely the most vulnerable targets of an interlinked “Inferior-Foreigner” racialization. Not only is this true of the Black immigrant Muslims who have been accused of, or charged with, terrorist activity, but of public figures like Black British rapper 21 Savage who the Trump Administration deported. It also applies to Asian Americans who have long been blackened for living conditions more associated with Black Americans, such as Southeast Asian ethnics who live in inner-cities, engage in gang activity, underperform in schools, and are enrolled in welfare programs (Ong 1996; see Fujiwara 2008).

To conclude, my critiques notwithstanding, racial triangulation is still a brilliant tour de force that broke new ground and remains enormously useful. It has been widely applied across disciplines and subject matter, and has been a key theoretical inspiration for my work and that of many others. As such, Kim’s supplanting of racial triangulation with a model defined by Asian Americans being “*not-white but above all not-black*” (we authors were sent her book abstract to inform this critical essay), I argue that would be a major step backwards, both for theory and praxis. At this moment when over 3000 covid-19 hate crimes against Asian Americans have been reported and when South Asian Americans have been swept up in the Trumpian spike in anti-Muslim crimes – and both are vastly underreported, as most Asian ethnics feel invisible in the US – we need theories that can fully account for these major tenets of White supremacy. Why does the model minority racialization hold no purchase at the moment; what determines when it does and when it does not? Why do all groups of color become perpetrators of White supremacist violence against one another? Expanding and improving racial triangulation theory would get us there, moving away from it would not.

## Note

1. By “(neo)imperialism” I am referring to the post-World War II period in which a powerful state has intervened into another by way of military armament and restructuring of capital, the military side of which cannot be overstated (Glick Schiller 2005, 453). Without military force, the presence and profitable aims of capital (including dissemination of cultural “soft power”) are often not secured. By “(neo/post)colonialism” I refer to the fact that the Global North and Global South became constituted – economically, politically, socio-culturally, and unequally – as they are owing to the former’s colonization of the latter. I would add that this (and [neo]imperialism) involve the Global North’s institutionalization of racialized and intersectional social orders to prop up its domination. By “(neo)liberalism” I refer to the discursive-material system that emerged under the 1980s’ Reagan Era which strengthened the laissez-faire nature of (global) capitalism and withered the social welfare state; this empowers the market to dictate what happens in every sector (eg, privatizes public goods), relies on an extreme rendering of individualism (not neoliberal injustices) as destiny, and pivots on white supremacy, patriarchy, and the like to consolidate the monopoly of the white (male) 1%.

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